
SENTIENTIA LMS

Ninja Server Deployment & AWS RDS Installation Guidebook

Moodle 5.2 fresh install | Complete standalone package

Document	Sentientia LMS - Moodle 5.2 Ninja/RDS Deployment Guidebook
Audience	IT / Infrastructure team (temporary ninja-server rehearsal)
Package	Sentientia-LMS-5.2-Complete-Standalone-2026-08-03.zip
Package size	155 MB (161,905,271 bytes)
SHA-256	bd4b16ef37514b95bb442a75564f3799d30bd3cfe183073d640be61063612cd7
Target platform	Moodle 5.2 (branch 502) - PHP 8.3 + MySQL 8.4 (AWS RDS)
Prepared	2026-08-03 (L&D Engineering) - Owner: Nitin Rajput
Status	Deploy candidate - static-validated (0 blockers) + all UI fixes through 2026-08-03; ninja run = first 5.2 runtime validation

Live deploy is gated.

This guidebook covers a **temporary ninja / sandbox** deployment only. Production go-live on [airpay.academy](#) remains a separate, owner-gated decision. Nothing here should be pointed at production data or DNS without explicit sign-off.

Contents

1. Overview & deployment topology
 2. Prerequisites (hard requirements)
 3. AWS infrastructure - EC2 app server + RDS database
 4. App-server preparation (PHP 8.3, web server, TLS)
 5. Installation - step by step (fresh install)
 6. Post-install verification
 7. Feature flags & the competitive gap cohort
 8. Security & hardening
 9. Teardown (temporary ninja)
 10. Troubleshooting
- Appendix A - RDS parameter-group cheat sheet
- Appendix B - PHP extension checklist
- Appendix C - Package manifest & contents
- Appendix D - Command quick-reference

1. Overview & deployment topology

This package is the **complete Moodle 5.2 web root with all Sentientia LMS customisations already applied** - the platform core, all bundled PHP dependencies (vendor libraries under `lib/`), the `theme_sentientia` theme, 46 `local_sentientia_*` plugins, 6 blocks, the Airpay payment gateway, the proctoring quiz-access rule, and the certificate tool. No GitHub checkout, no Composer install, and no Node build are required on the server - the tree is ready to run.

Three things are deliberately **not** in the package and must be provided per-instance (covered below): the `site config.php` (contains DB credentials), the `moodledata` directory, and the database itself.

Target topology

Tier	Component	Notes
Edge	ALB / Nginx (TLS 443)	Terminates HTTPS; forwards to the app server. Certbot on the box is fine for a ninja.
App	EC2 - Apache 2.4 + PHP 8.3	Serves the docroot <code>.../moodle5.2/public</code> . Holds the code + moodledata.
Data	AWS RDS - MySQL 8.4	Managed database. Reached privately over port 3306 from the app security group only.

Fresh install vs. data restore

This guide follows the **fresh-install** path (empty database, new admin account) as requested. If you instead need to rehearse the live-data migration, restore the provided DB + moodledata backup *before* running the upgrade step - see §5.6 note.

2. Prerequisites (hard requirements)

Moodle 5.2 will not run on the current production stack.

It requires **PHP 8.3+** and **MySQL 8.4+ / MariaDB 10.11+**. PHP 8.2 or MySQL 8.0 will fail the installer's environment check and the site will not boot. Provision the ninja to the versions in the table below - do not match the current prod RDS (8.0.44) or local (PHP 8.2).

Component	Required	Notes
Operating system	Ubuntu 24.04 LTS (or 22.04) / Amazon Linux 2023	64-bit. Examples below use Ubuntu/apt; translate to dnf on AL2023.
PHP	8.3.x (8.3.6+)	CLI + web SAPI must match. 8.4 also acceptable if all extensions load.
Database	AWS RDS MySQL 8.4 (or MariaDB 10.11+)	utf8mb4 throughout. See §3.2-3.3.
Web server	Apache 2.4 (mod_php or php-fpm) or Nginx 1.24+ + php-fpm	mod_rewrite / try_files required for clean URLs.
Memory	4 GB RAM min (8 GB recommended)	PHP memory_limit 256M+; opcache 256M.
Disk	25 GB+ on the app server	Code ~1.5 GB extracted + moodledata (grows with uploads).
Outbound HTTPS	Allowed (443)	For Moodle updates check, OAuth, and optional AI/WhatsApp features (all default OFF).

3. AWS infrastructure - EC2 app server + RDS database

3.1 EC2 (application server)

Setting	Ninja value
Instance type	t3.large (2 vCPU / 8 GB) recommended; t3.medium minimum
AMI	Ubuntu Server 24.04 LTS (x86_64)
Root volume	gp3, 30 GB
Security group (app)	Inbound: 443 + 80 from ALB/world; 22 from admin IP only. Outbound: all.

3.2 RDS (MySQL 8.4)

Setting	Ninja value
Engine	MySQL 8.4.x (NOT 8.0). MariaDB 10.11+ is an alternative engine.
Instance class	db.t3.medium (2 vCPU / 4 GB) is ample for a ninja
Storage	gp3, 50 GB, autoscaling optional
Multi-AZ	No (single-AZ is fine for a temporary sandbox)
Public access	No - private subnet; reachable only from the app SG
DB name	Leave blank at create time; create it explicitly (\$3.5) with utf8mb4
Master user	e.g. sentientia_admin (used once to create the app DB + user)
Backups	Default; for a throwaway ninja you may set retention low

3.3 RDS parameter group (critical for Moodle)

Create a custom **DB parameter group** (family `mysql8.4`) and set the values below, then attach it to the instance and reboot. Defaults are close, but character set and packet size must be correct *before* the schema is created.

Parameter	Value	Why
<code>character_set_server</code>	<code>utf8mb4</code>	Moodle 5.x mandates full utf8mb4 (4-byte) storage.
<code>collation_server</code>	<code>utf8mb4_unicode_ci</code>	Consistent collation for all tables.
<code>innodb_file_per_table</code>	<code>1</code>	Required for large-row DYNAMIC format tables.
<code>max_allowed_packet</code>	<code>67108864 (64M)</code>	Large content / backup rows. 8.4 defaults to 64M - confirm.
<code>innodb_buffer_pool_size</code>	<code>~70% of instance RAM</code>	Primary performance lever.
<code>wait_timeout</code>	<code>28800</code>	Avoid premature disconnects during long CLI upgrades.
<code>log_bin_trust_function_creators</code>	<code>1</code>	Only if a restore that recreates routines errors; harmless to set.

3.4 Security groups

- **RDS SG:** inbound TCP 3306 *from the app-server SG id only* (never 0.0.0.0/0).
- **App SG:** inbound 443/80 from the load balancer (or world for a quick ninja), 22 from your admin IP.

3.5 Create the application database + user

Connect to the RDS endpoint with the master user and run:

```
mysql -h <RDS-ENDPOINT> -u sentientia_admin -p

CREATE DATABASE sentientia
  CHARACTER SET utf8mb4 COLLATE utf8mb4_unicode_ci;

CREATE USER 'sentientia_app'@ '%' IDENTIFIED BY '<STRONG-PASSWORD>';
GRANT ALL PRIVILEGES ON sentientia.* TO 'sentientia_app'@ '%';
FLUSH PRIVILEGES;
```

Credential handling

Generate the DB password in your secrets manager. It goes only into `config.php` on the app server (file mode 0640, owner `www-data`). Never commit it, never place it in the repo, and never paste it into a browser field.

4. App-server preparation

4.1 Install PHP 8.3 + extensions (Ubuntu)

```
sudo add-apt-repository ppa:ondrej/php # if 8.3 not in base repo
sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y apache2 \
  php8.3 libapache2-mod-php8.3 php8.3-cli \
  php8.3-mysql php8.3-xml php8.3-mbstring php8.3-curl \
  php8.3-zip php8.3-gd php8.3-intl php8.3-soap \
  php8.3-bcmath php8.3-ldap php8.3-openssl
sudo a2enmod rewrite ssl headers expires
php -v # confirm 8.3.x
```

The full required/recommended extension list is in **Appendix B**. The web installer (§6) re-checks every one and reports any that are missing.

4.2 PHP settings (php.ini for both CLI and Apache SAPI)

Directive	Value	Notes
memory_limit	256M (512M rec.)	Some reports/backups need headroom.
max_input_vars	5000	Large admin forms exceed the 1000 default.
post_max_size	100M	Course / SCORM uploads.
upload_max_filesize	100M	Match or below post_max_size.
max_execution_time	300	CLI is unlimited; this is for web.
date.timezone	Asia/Kolkata	Set explicitly to avoid warnings.
opcache.enable	1	Strongly recommended in production mode.
opcache.memory_consumption	256	Large codebase.
opcache.max_accelerated_files	20000	Moodle ships thousands of files.
opcache.revalidate_freq	60	Set 2-5 for a ninja you will edit; 60 for stable.

4.3 Apache virtual host (docroot = the public/ folder)

Docroot must be the public/ sub-folder.

Moodle 5.x uses the public-folder split. Point the web root at `.../moodle5.2/public`, NOT at `.../moodle5.2`. Serving the parent exposes `config.php` and CLI scripts.

```
<VirtualHost *:443>
    ServerName  ninja.sentientia.example
    DocumentRoot /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/public

    <Directory /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/public>
        Options FollowSymLinks
        AllowOverride All
        Require all granted
    </Directory>

    # Clean URLs (Moodle "slasharguments")
    # AllowOverride All lets Moodle's .htaccess handle rewriting.

    SSLEngine on
    SSLCertificateFile      /etc/letsencrypt/live/ninja.../fullchain.pem
    SSLCertificateKeyFile    /etc/letsencrypt/live/ninja.../privkey.pem
</VirtualHost>
```

4.4 TLS

- Quick ninja: `sudo certbot --apache -d ninja.sentientia.example`.
- AWS-native: terminate TLS at an ALB with an ACM certificate and forward 80/443 to the instance.
- Moodle must know it is on HTTPS - set `$CFG->wwwroot` to the `https://` URL (§5.4).

5. Installation - step by step (fresh install)

5.1 Upload & extract

```
sudo mkdir -p /var/www/sentientia
# copy the zip to the server, then:
cd /var/www/sentientia
unzip /tmp/Sentientia-LMS-5.2-Complete-Standalone-2026-08-03.zip
# yields: /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/ (with public/ inside)
```

5.2 Create moodledata OUTSIDE the docroot

```
sudo mkdir -p /var/sentientiadata
sudo chown -R www-data:www-data /var/sentientiadata
sudo chmod 0770 /var/sentientiadata
```

5.3 Create config.php from the template

Copy `public/config-dist.php` to `moodle5.2/config.php` and set the key values:

```
$CFG->dbtype      = 'mysqli';
$CFG->dblibrary    = 'native';
$CFG->dbhost       = '<RDS-ENDPOINT>';
$CFG->dbname       = 'sentientia';
$CFG->dbuser       = 'sentientia_app';
$CFG->dbpass       = '<STRONG-PASSWORD>';
$CFG->prefix       = 'mdl_';
$CFG->dboptions    = ['dbcollation' => 'utf8mb4_unicode_ci'];

$CFG->wwwroot      = 'https://ninja.sentientia.example';
$CFG->dataroot     = '/var/sentientiadata';
$CFG->admin        = 'admin';
// require_once(__DIR__ . '/public/lib/setup.php'); // keep the template's tail
```

```
sudo chown -R www-data:www-data /var/www/sentientia
sudo chmod 0640 /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/config.php
```

5.4 Run the fresh install (CLI)

From the project root, create the schema + the admin account in one shot:

```
cd /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2
sudo -u www-data php admin/cli/install_database.php \
  --lang=en --adminuser=admin \
  --adminpass='<ADMIN-PASSWORD>' \
  --adminemail='it@airpay.co.in' \
  --fullname='Sentientia LMS (Ninja)' \
  --shortname='Sentientia' \
  --agree-license
```

Data-migration alternative (\$1).

For a data-restore rehearsal instead of a fresh install: import the provided DB dump into RDS and copy the moodledata (including filedir/) into /var/sentientiadata BEFORE this step, then run `php admin/cli/upgrade.php --non-interactive` in place of `install_database.php`.

5.5 Purge caches & (optional) post-deploy CLIs

```
sudo -u www-data php admin/cli/purge_caches.php

# optional, safe to run; needed after data restore, harmless on fresh:
sudo -u www-data php public/local/sentientia_platform/cli/repair_task_registrations.php --apply
sudo -u www-data php public/local/sentientia_catalog/cli/enable_oneclick_enrol.php
```

5.6 Cron (mandatory)

Moodle needs cron every minute or scheduled tasks, notifications, and completion stop working:

```
sudo crontab -u www-data -e
# add:
* * * * * /usr/bin/php /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/admin/cli/cron.php >/dev/null 2>&1
```

6. Post-install verification

Log in as admin and confirm, in order:

#	Check	Expected
1	Site administration → Notifications	No environment failures; "Database" + "PHP version" rows green.
2	Site administration → Server → Environment	PHP 8.3 OK, MySQL 8.4 OK, all required extensions OK.

#	Check	Expected
3	Dashboard loads for admin	Sentientia theme renders; no raw {{ }}; browser console 0 errors.
4	Open a course + a plugin page	Pages render; AMD modules boot (charts / cart badge active).
5	Run the link/persona gate	From moodle-enhancement/tools/gap-test/ - overwhelmingly healthy.
6	Feature flags	Gap-cohort features default OFF (\$7) - confirm before any demo.

This is the first real 5.2 runtime.

The candidate passed static validation (php -l, schema, deprecation, AMD parity - 0 blockers) but has not run on 5.2 before. Treat the ninja boot as validation: capture any Notifications-page warning and the Apache error log, and report before pointing anyone at it.

7. Feature flags & the competitive gap cohort

The package bundles an 11-feature "competitive gap" cohort (AI authoring, skills intelligence, content marketplace, predictive analytics, agentic assistant, xAPI/LRS, talent mobility, public API/LTI, etc.). Every one ships **feature-flagged OFF and in mock mode** (no external AI spend). Default behaviour matches today's Airpay Academy.

- Keep all gap flags OFF for the initial ninja boot - verify the core platform first.
- Flags live in `local_sentientia_core` `feature_flags` (per-customer + per-tenant overridable).
- AI / WhatsApp / ElevenLabs integrations need real API keys in a server .env and stay dormant until both the key and the flag are set.

8. Security & hardening

- **config.php** mode 0640, owner www-data. Never world-readable.
- **moodledata** outside the docroot (\$5.2). Confirm `https://.../sentientiadata` is NOT web-reachable.
- **RDS** reachable only from the app SG; no public access; TLS to the DB if your policy requires it.
- **HTTPS only** - redirect 80→443; set an HSTS header once you are confident.
- **Admin account** - strong password; enable 2FA (`tool_mfa` is bundled) before any external exposure.
- **Debugging OFF** - do not enable developer debug on an internet-facing ninja.
- **Secrets** - DB password + any API keys via the OS/secure store, never in the repo tree.

9. Teardown (temporary ninja)

When the rehearsal is complete:

- Terminate the EC2 instance (or stop it to preserve the volume for a later run).
- Delete the RDS instance - for a throwaway ninja you may skip the final snapshot.
- Remove `/var/sentientiadata` if it held any real learner data.
- Revoke the ninja DNS record and the TLS certificate if issued per-host.

10. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
Installer aborts on "PHP version"	PHP < 8.3	Install/enable PHP 8.3; confirm CLI and web SAPI both report 8.3.
Installer aborts on database version	RDS is MySQL 8.0	Recreate RDS on the mysql8.4 engine (§3.2).
"Incorrect string value" on install	DB not utf8mb4	Fix the parameter group (§3.3), recreate the DB with utf8mb4, reinstall.
config.php exposed / CLI in browser	Docroot points at parent	Set docroot to ../moodle5.2/public (§4.3).
Pages load but no charts / dead buttons	AMD not served or caches stale	Confirm files exist under amd/build/; run purge_caches.php; hard-refresh.
Clean URLs 404	mod_rewrite off / AllowOverride None	a2enmod rewrite; AllowOverride All; reload Apache.
Notifications / completion not firing	Cron not running	Add the www-data crontab entry (§5.6); check cron.php runs.
"Cannot write to dataroot"	moodledata perms	chown www-data + chmod 0770 on /var/sentientidata.

Appendix A - RDS parameter-group cheat sheet

Parameter	Value
character_set_server	utf8mb4
collation_server	utf8mb4_unicode_ci
innodb_file_per_table	1
max_allowed_packet	67108864
innodb_buffer_pool_size	~70% of RAM (bytes)
wait_timeout	28800
log_bin_trust_function_creators	1 (if restore needs it)

Appendix B - PHP extension checklist

Required (installer blocks without these): ctype, curl, dom, gd, iconv, intl, json, mbstring, openssl, pcre, SimpleXML, soap, spl, xml, xmlreader, zip, mysqli.

Recommended: opcache, ldap, exif, fileinfo, sodium, tokenizer.

Verify: `php -m | sort`, or read the Notifications / Environment page after install (it flags any gap explicitly).

Appendix C - Package manifest & contents

Attribute	Value
File	Sentientia-LMS-5.2-Complete-Standalone-2026-08-03.zip
Size	155 MB (161,905,271 bytes)
SHA-256	bd4b16ef 37514b95 bb442a75 564f3799 d30bd3cf e183073d 640be610 63612cd7
Extracts to	moodle5.2/ (public/ inside = docroot)
Includes	Moodle 5.2 core + all bundled vendor libs; theme_sentientia; 46 local_sentientia_* plugins; 6 sentientia_* blocks; paygw_airpay; sentientia_proctoring; tool_certificate
Excludes	config.php (secret); moodledata / filedir; database; node_modules + dev tooling; stale/quarantine dirs
Verified	php -l 1,567/0 errors; schema well-formed; 0 theme_airpayux survivors; no DB-cred config, no .env/keys in zip

Verify the download before extracting:

```
# Linux
sha256sum Sentientia-LMS-5.2-Complete-Standalone-2026-08-03.zip
# must equal:
# bd4b16ef37514b95bb442a75564f3799d30bd3cfe183073d640be61063612cd7
```

Appendix D - Command quick-reference

```
# 1. extract
cd /var/www/sentientia && unzip <package>.zip
# 2. moodledata
sudo mkdir -p /var/sentientiadata && sudo chown www-data:www-data /var/sentientiadata && sudo chmod 0770 /va
# 3. config.php (edit dbhost/dbname/dbuser/dbpass/wwwroot/dataroot)
sudo cp moodle5.2/public/config-dist.php moodle5.2/config.php
# 4. ownership
sudo chown -R www-data:www-data /var/www/sentientia && sudo chmod 0640 moodle5.2/config.php
# 5. fresh install
cd moodle5.2 && sudo -u www-data php admin/cli/install_database.php --adminpass='***' --adminemail='it@airpa
# 6. caches + cron
sudo -u www-data php admin/cli/purge_caches.php
sudo crontab -u www-data -e # * * * * * php /var/www/sentientia/moodle5.2/admin/cli/cron.php >/dev/null 2>
```

End of guidebook. Package + this PDF are in the deploy bundle. Live production go-live remains owner-gated.